

7 Healthy Lunch Tips for the Busy Executive

Stay energised and well-nourished throughout your workday by maintaining a balanced diet with a healthy lunch.

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Feedback

Healthy Eating At Work

It is lunch hour once again! You have just about an hour to grab a bite and get back to work. Are you wondering what you should eat? If you are on a quest for good nutrition and a healthy diet, here are seven effective steps to help you eat better and encourage your colleagues to do so as well.

1. Practice Healthy Eating by Choosing Items With Lesser

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ACCEPT

- Watch out for meat with visible fat layers.
- Limit dishes with a layer of fat floating on the surface or those cooked with cream.
- If you want to eat a one-dish noodle meal, go for the clear noodle soups instead of fried noodle or noodle doused with thick and oily sauce.

If you cannot guestimate the nutritional content of a dish in front of you, ask the service staff how it is cooked. The exchange of information may help you determine if the dish you want to eat is high in fat, saturated fat, cholesterol and/or sodium.

Preferably buy and eat packaged food that carries the Healthier Choice Symbol. Alternatively, you can read the Nutrition Information Panel if it is included on the food packaging. Use the figures to pick items with less fat, saturated fat, cholesterol and sodium. If the product does not list the quantitative information on the label, then study the ingredient list. Beware of high-fat ingredients (e.g. vegetable oils, shortening, hydrogenated oils) and added sugar (e.g. sugar, honey, glucose) and added salt (e.g. sodium chloride, sea salt).

2. Ask for More Vegetables for a More Balanced Diet

Always ask for more vegetables as you need to eat enough to meet your veggie goal for the day. If you order economy rice, you can pick two different brightly coloured vegetables, including one dark green leafy vegetable such as spinach, chye sim or kangkong. This will help you to get enough for the day and harness the nutritional benefits of variety. When you order a one-dish noodle meal, specifically ask for more vegetables. Though you may need to pay a little more, it is worth getting the extra veggies for your health.

3. Limit Food High in Sodium

Excessive sodium intake is associated with elevated blood pressure. As you pick your foods, bear these tips in mind for a healthier lunch:

- Limit salty soups or dishes found soaking in sauces such as soya sauce, fish sauce

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- Ask the caterer to serve you less sauces and gravies as these are usually high in sodium.
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4. End Your Meal With Fresh Fruit

Many of us like a sweet ending to every meal, so we unconsciously reach out for dessert, candy or chocolate to satisfy our craving. These popular items are high in sugar and sometimes fat. If you indulge in them often, you will pile on the unnecessary calories and gain weight.

The most nutritious sweet ending to a meal is fresh fruit. Most workplace canteens in Singapore usually offer a variety of cut fruit, so take advantage of the nicely peeled and portioned fruit to fulfil your daily fruit recommendation and satisfy your longing for something sweet.

5. Make the Healthier Choice, Avoid Sweetened Drinks

If you have slipped into the habit of accompanying your lunch with a sweetened drink, then replace it with water. Not only will you save some money, but you will also save plenty of calories, which would otherwise have added to your weight and your waistline.

You might also enjoy sipping on hot coffee or tea throughout the day to stay alert. If you drink your coffee and tea neat, that is fine, but if you like adding sugar, then you may want to cut down. These additions can contribute to extra calories. Gradually reduce the amount used, and you will be surprised that your taste buds can be reconditioned to accept a less sweet taste.

If you need to drink a sweetened beverage, choose drinks labelled with the Healthier Choice Symbol (HCS) lower in sugar or Nutri-Grade A or B, or ask for Kosong.

6. Choose a Balanced Diet

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If there aren't many healthier options at the workplace, why not pack lunch from home? Place it in the refrigerator at work, reheat in the microwave, and you can eat the nutritious meal that you personally cook up. Your health is really worth all the effort!

7. Eat Just Enough

Exercise portion control to manage your weight. Do not indulge in large portions or extra servings. You can tell the canteen staff or food vendor to serve you less rather than accept what they put on your plate. If you are bored or stressed at work, do not simply turn to food! Relax by talking to your colleagues, going for a short walk or working out at the gym.

So Remember

- Select a balanced and healthy lunch meal that includes a staple, vegetable, low-fat protein, and fruit. Opt for dishes cooked healthily to make them low in fat, saturated fat, cholesterol, sodium and sugar. Make an effort to include more wholegrains, fruit, and vegetables to pep up the fibre and nutrient density of your meal. If you cannot get a healthy meal during lunch hour despite all your efforts, pack a nutritious lunch and bring it from home.
- Even if you are tempted, do not overeat. Serve up your regular portion on your plate and avoid eating or drinking any extras.

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